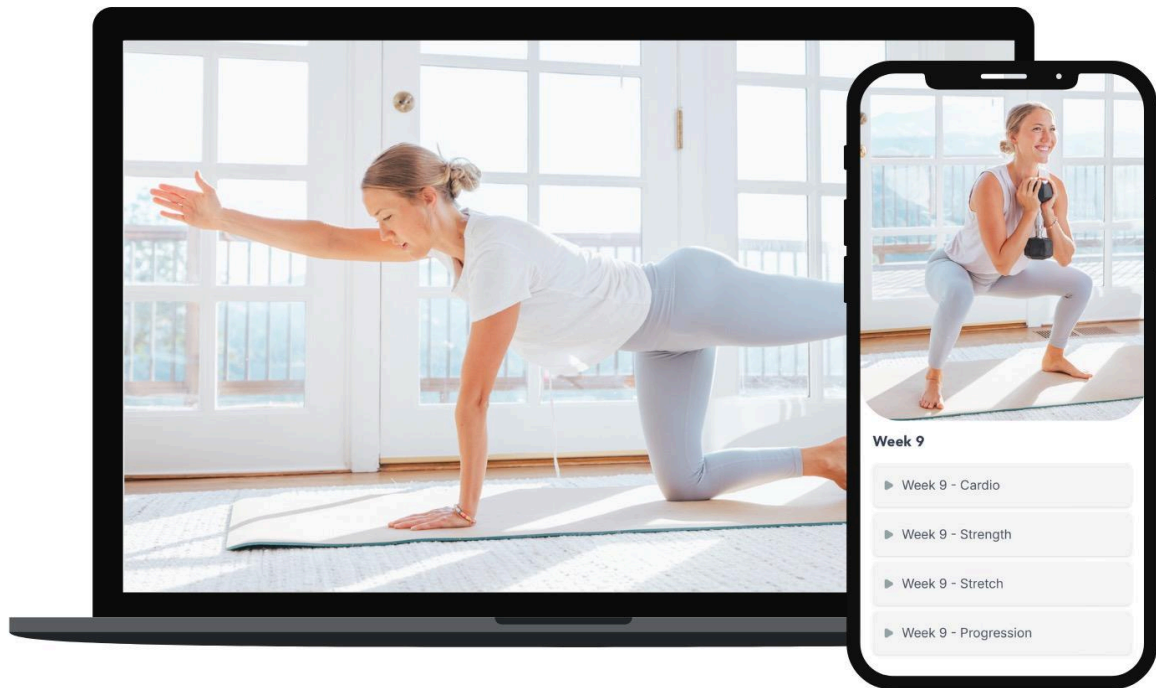




UX Research Case Study — Postpartum Fitness App

Understanding the needs and challenges of new mothers to inform a safe and motivating mobile experience

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Full research documentation:

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Research goal

The goal of this research was to understand the needs, motivations, behaviors, and pain points of new mothers in order to inform the design of a postpartum fitness mobile app. The app should support users in returning to exercise in a way that feels safe, realistic, and achievable during a postpartum period.

To design a solution that truly supports new mothers we need to understand their everyday reality, not just their fitness goals. These research questions helped us explore their routines, emotional drivers, physical limitations and the context in which exercise needs to fit into daily life.



The purpose of this study is to identify the key challenges women face after giving birth and gather insights into their behaviors, needs and expectations. These insights form the foundation for designing a supportive, user-friendly and engaging postpartum fitness application.

Research methods

To better understand the needs and challenges of new mothers, we used a mix of different research methods. Combining these approaches helped us see both the user perspective and the bigger market context.

1. Primary Research

We conducted primary research to collect information directly from the source the users themselves. This gave us real insights into their daily lives, routines, and struggles with postpartum exercise.

2. Exploratory Research (Qualitative)

We used exploratory research because this is an area where we didn't have a full picture from the start. The goal was to explore the problem more openly and gain a deeper understanding of users' needs, emotions and experiences.

3. Secondary Research

We also used secondary research, which means gathering information that has already been published. This included looking at recommended types of postnatal exercise, common challenges after childbirth and features offered in existing apps.

By combining these methods, we got a more complete understanding of user behaviors and needs. Primary research gave us personal insights from real mothers, while secondary research helped us understand the broader context and existing solutions. Exploratory research helped us shape and clarify the problem we were trying to solve.

Research Method 1: Semi-Structured Interviews

As part of the exploratory research phase, we conducted semi-structured interviews. We chose this method because we needed to understand the real-life context of new mothers and avoid designing a solution that doesn't match their actual needs.

Semi-structured interviews gave us a balance between structure and flexibility.

We had prepared topics and guiding questions, but we could still ask follow-up questions and explore interesting areas that came up during the conversation.



This helped us get more personal and detailed insights into the mothers' experiences, challenges and motivations around postpartum exercise.

Through one-on-one conversations we were able to better understand how daily routines, emotions, physical recovery and lack of time affect their ability to exercise. These insights were important for shaping a mobile app that feels realistic and supportive in everyday life.

Why this method

In-depth interviews provide detailed insights into users' feelings, thoughts and experiences. They help to understand users' motivations and deeper needs.

Benefits

- Allowed follow-up questions
- Made it possible to explore personal challenges in more detail
- Gave more nuanced insights than surveys would

Purpose

To gather qualitative insights from new mothers about their experiences, needs, and challenges related to postnatal exercise.

Participants

3 mothers who had given birth within the last 6–12 months.

Format

Semi-structured, one-on-one interviews.

Main topics covered

Daily routines, current exercise habits, motivations, barriers, and expectations for a postpartum fitness app.

Research Method 2: Competitor analysis (secondary research)

Why this method: To understand the market and identify best practices as well as potential areas for improvement. It helps to position our application uniquely.

Benefits: Provides a comprehensive understanding of the competitive landscape. Can inspire new ideas and features.



Purpose: To understand the strengths and weaknesses of existing fitness apps aimed at new mothers.

Apps to Analyze: Three popular postnatal fitness apps.

Criteria: Usability, features, user reviews, and overall design.

Literature Review (secondary research)

Why: We have chosen literature review as a method because it helps us to conduct secondary research using reliable sources to collect and organize data on the topics related to our research objectives.

Benefits: Find the most important facts and insights according to our research goals.

Purpose: To gather background information on postnatal exercises, their benefits, and common challenges faced by new mothers.

Sources: Academic articles, health websites, and fitness blogs.

Timeline /Tools and Techniques

Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
- Recruitment of participants. - Script for the semi-interview.	- Conducting interviews. - Litterature Review	Observations and competitive analysis.	- Analysis and synthesis of data. - Development of personas, customer journey maps.	Presentation av research findings och designförslag.
Tools and Techniques: see interview guide The Basics of Recruiting Participants for User Research GDPR The 3 Types of User Interviews: Structured, Semi-structured, and Unstructured	Tools: Interviews: Zoom, Skype, or Google Meet. Notebook & Pen, Phone to record,	Tools and Techniques: Observations: In- person observations or video clips.	Tools and Techniques Analysis: Miro for affinity diagrams.	

Interviews summary

Participants:

1. Anna 28 year single mother living in Boden Sweden (gave birth 7 months ago)
2. Elin 34 years old living with her partner in Stockholm Sweden (gave birth 10 months ago)
3. Anna, 43 year old living in Stockholm, Sweden with her husband (gave birth 9 months ago)

Interview Script

Introduction:

- Thank you for participating in this interview. Your insights are invaluable for our research. Before we begin, could you please provide some basic information about yourself, such as your age, occupation, and how long ago you gave birth?

Who will the mobile application be for, and what are their characteristics?

- Can you describe your daily routine as a new mother?
- How do you prioritize self-care and exercise in your daily life?
- Are you currently engaged in any postnatal exercise routine?

What would motivate the user to use the application?

- What are your main motivations for wanting to engage in postnatal exercise?
- What barriers or challenges do you face when trying to incorporate exercise into your routine?

When would the application be used?

- What times of the day do you find most suitable for engaging in exercise?
- Are there specific times or situations where you feel more inclined to use a mobile application for exercise guidance?

Where would it be used?

- Can you describe where you typically exercise, whether it's at home, outdoors, or at a gym?

- Are there any specific locations where you would prefer to use a mobile application for exercise support?

Why is this product important?

- In your opinion, what role does postnatal exercise play in your overall well-being?
- How do you think a mobile application could support you in your postnatal fitness journey?

How would it work and help users?

- What features or functionalities would you like to see in a postnatal exercise application?
- How do you envision using a mobile application to track your progress and stay motivated?

Conclusion:

- Is there anything else you would like to share regarding your experiences with postnatal exercise or your expectations for a mobile application designed for this purpose?
- Thank you once again for your time and valuable insights. Your input will greatly contribute to the development of a user-friendly and effective postnatal exercise application.

(Full interview scripts: [📄 interviews](#))

Interview Insights

Across all interviews, several themes appeared consistently:

1) Time and energy are the biggest barriers

Mothers described unpredictable schedules and constant fatigue. Even when they were motivated, building consistent exercise habits felt difficult.

2) Home-based, flexible workouts feel most realistic

All participants said that exercising at home was the most practical option, often during nap times or in the evening.

3) Safety and confidence matter

Participants wanted reassurance that workouts are safe for postpartum bodies and adapted to conditions such as pelvic floor weakness, diastasis rect and C-section recovery.

4) Support increases motivation

Mothers expressed a need for reminders, progress tracking, and encouragement. Community support was also seen as motivating, especially for those who lacked friends in a similar life stage.

5) Nutrition is highly valued

Nutrition tracking and postpartum adapted meal guidance were seen as valuable additions, especially when personalized.

Competitive Analysis

As part of the secondary research, we conducted a competitive analysis to understand how existing postpartum fitness apps support new mothers and where there are opportunities for improvement.

Why this method

The goal was to understand the current market, identify best practices, and find gaps where a new solution could offer more value.

Sources used

We used a mix of primary and secondary sources:

Primary sources

- Interviews with women who had given birth within the last 12 months
- Direct exploration and testing of the apps

Secondary sources

- Company websites
- News articles and press coverage
- Social media profiles and interactions
- Online customer reviews and ratings

Apps analyzed

- **Juna**
- **Baby2Body**
- **The Bloom Method**

Comparison criteria

We compared the apps based on:

- Nutrition advice
- Workout content and variety
- Pricing
- Usability and design
- Holistic wellness and self-care content
- Access to a social community

App Observations

Juna

Nutrition

Offers personalized nutrition plans tailored to postpartum needs, including hormone-balancing foods, meal plans, recipes, and nutritional tips.



Workout Content

Provides a variety of postpartum-friendly workouts such as strength training, cardio, and yoga. Users appreciate the diversity but wish for a larger workout library.

Pricing

Mid-range pricing with monthly, quarterly, and annual plans. Includes a 7-day free trial.

Design

Praised for its clean, intuitive, and easy-to-navigate interface.

Holistic Wellness

Strong focus on mental and emotional well-being, including meditation, breathing exercises, and mindfulness practices.

Community

Offers a built-in community and access to a private Facebook group for peer support.

Baby2Body

Nutrition

Provides personalized nutrition plans based on dietary preferences and health goals. Includes recipes and guidance on hydration and essential nutrients.

Workout Content

Offers expert-led workouts but users report wanting more variety.

Pricing

The most affordable of the three apps, with similar pricing tiers and a 7-day free trial.

Design

Some users find the app overwhelming due to the amount of content. Reports of technical and navigation issues.

Holistic Wellness

Strong focus on overall well-being, including expert advice on recovery, parenting, and stress management.

Community

Includes social features, but engagement feels less structured compared to Juna.

The Bloom Method

Nutrition

Provides general dietary guidance that complements fitness routines but is less focused on recipes or detailed meal planning.

Workout Content

Strong emphasis on expert guidance and pelvic floor health. Some workouts may feel too advanced for beginners.

Pricing

Premium pricing, higher than the other apps, with a longer free trial.

Design

Generally well-received and easy to navigate.

Holistic Wellness

Combines wellness support with expert-led guidance and stress-reduction practices.

Community

Offers access to expert discussions, forums, and live Q&A sessions.

Key Insights from Competitive Analysis

- A wide range of workout videos and different fitness levels is essential. There needs to be a balance between beginner-friendly and more challenging sessions to support users at different stages of recovery. A strong focus on core and pelvic floor health is especially important.
- An intuitive and easy-to-navigate design has a major impact on the overall user experience.
- Users prefer clean interfaces that make it easy to access features without feeling overwhelmed. Technical issues quickly create frustration and reduce engagement.

- Access to a social community increases motivation and long-term engagement. Features such as peer support groups (like Juna's private community) and real-time expert interaction (as seen in The Bloom Method) add significant value.
- Expert guidance is highly appreciated and increases users' confidence and sense of safety when exercising postpartum.
- Lower pricing lowers the barrier to trying an app, but many mothers are willing to invest in more expensive options if they clearly see the value through comprehensive resources and expert support.
- Personalized nutrition advice is important, especially when tailored to postpartum needs.
- Support for mental and emotional well-being is an important part of a postpartum fitness experience and should be included alongside physical training.

Literature Review

To support our user research with evidence-based knowledge, we conducted a literature review on postpartum exercise, recovery, and digital health solutions for new mothers.

Research Questions

1. What are the benefits of postnatal exercise for new mothers?
2. What challenges do new mothers face when trying to include exercise in daily life?

3. What are current market trends in postnatal fitness apps, and which features are most valued by users?

Benefits of Postnatal Exercise

Research highlights several physical and mental health benefits of postpartum exercise:

- Improved energy levels and reduced fatigue
- Enhanced mood and reduced symptoms of depression
- Improved cardiovascular fitness and restored muscle strength
- Reduced stress and anxiety
- Support in preventing postnatal depression

These findings show that exercise plays an important role not only in physical recovery but also in emotional well-being during the postpartum period.

Challenges Faced by New Mothers

Despite the benefits, research shows that many mothers struggle to stay active after childbirth. Common challenges include:

- Lack of time and energy while caring for a newborn
- Physical limitations such as pelvic floor weakness and diastasis recti
- Emotional distress, anxiety, and postpartum depression
- Limited access to childcare and support systems

This confirms that postpartum fitness solutions must be realistic, flexible, and supportive not demanding.

What Mothers Think About Fitness Apps

Studies about postpartum fitness apps show that:

- Mothers generally find these apps helpful and relevant
- Usability and simple navigation are very important
- Many women worry about safety and whether exercises are suitable postpartum
- Time constraints and low motivation are common barriers to app use
- Users prefer apps that offer personalized workouts and social support

Some reported experiences from mothers include:

"I liked the app because it was easy to use and had a variety of exercises."

"I was worried about getting injured, but the app made me feel more secure."

"I wish the app had more personalized guidance and support."

These insights highlight the importance of trust, clarity, and personalization.

Postpartum Exercise Guidelines

The literature also emphasizes that postpartum recovery is highly individual and requires careful guidance.

Early Recovery

Light movement can support circulation and healing, but rest is essential in cases of more severe physical recovery needs.

Assessing Capacity

Two commonly used approaches:

- **Traffic Light Model** (green = safe, yellow = caution, red = stop)
- **24-hour rule** (no lasting pain or discomfort the day after exercise)

Pelvic Floor Health

Pelvic floor training is crucial. Exercises should focus on improving strength, function, and endurance through controlled activation.

C-Section Recovery



Women recovering from a C-section often have lifting and movement restrictions for the first 6–8 weeks and need adapted exercises.

Return to Intense Training

Returning too quickly to high training loads can increase risk of injury. Gradual progression is important.

Long-term Pelvic Floor Symptoms

Some women experience ongoing pain, fear of movement, and reduced confidence. Support and professional guidance are important for recovery.

Role of Physical Therapy

Professional guidance can improve recovery outcomes and help manage symptoms safely.

Breathing & Pressure Management

Breathing techniques can help reduce pressure on the pelvic floor during movement.

Importance of Communication

Education, reassurance, and emotional support are essential. Recovery takes time, and realistic goal-setting is important.

Market Trends in Postnatal Fitness Apps

Current trends show a need for more:

- Evidence-based and medically informed content
- Personalized exercise and recovery guidance
- Short, flexible workouts for busy schedules
- Goal-setting and progress tracking
- Emotional and motivational support

- Community features to reduce isolation

Many existing apps lack structured goal-setting and clear postpartum-specific guidance.

Key Findings from the Literature Review

- Postnatal exercise plays an important role in new mothers' physical recovery, confidence, and overall well-being. This confirms that supporting movement after childbirth is not only about fitness, but also about mental health and quality of life.
- Many new mothers face significant barriers to exercise, including lack of energy, physical limitations, emotional distress, and limited access to childcare or support. This highlights the need for solutions that are flexible, realistic, and empathetic.
- There is a clear need for high-quality digital tools that are tailored specifically to postpartum needs. Generic fitness apps often fail to address recovery, safety, and emotional support.
- Understanding users' emotional and physical challenges is essential. Empathy-driven and user-centered design is especially important in sensitive life stages such as postpartum recovery.
- Evidence-based guidance is critical. Mothers need to trust that exercises and recommendations are safe and appropriate for their bodies after childbirth.

Conclusion

The literature shows that postnatal exercise has strong physical and mental health benefits, but many mothers struggle to integrate it into daily life. This reinforces the need for supportive, user-friendly, and evidence-based digital solutions that are designed around the real conditions of postpartum recovery.

Collecting The Data

[pain point mapping](#)

[Spreadsheet collecting data](#)

[Affinity mapping](#)

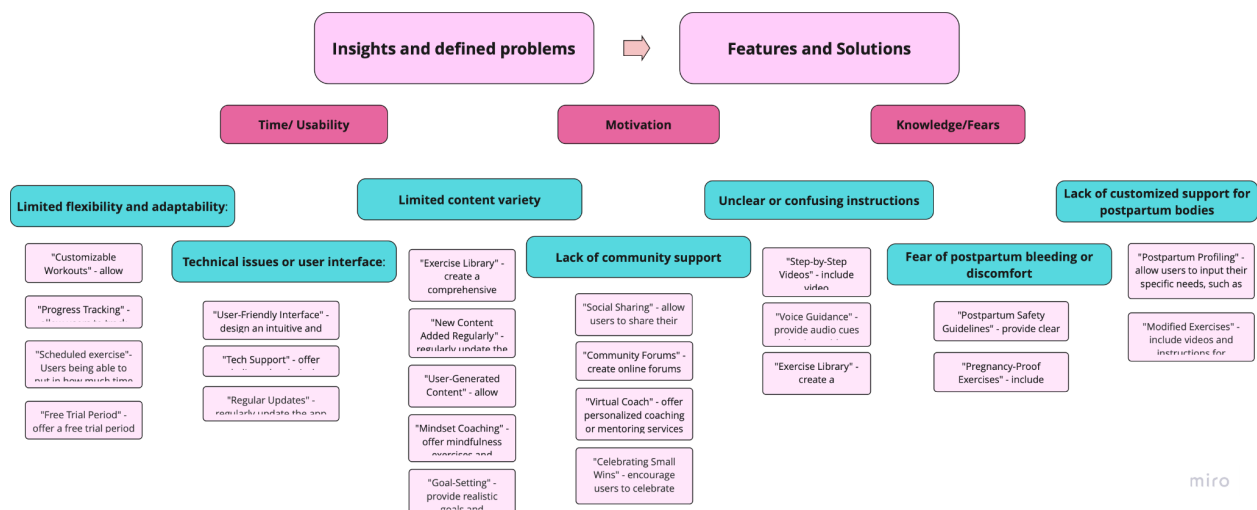
[Empathy mapping](#)

Design Recommendations Based on Research

Based on our interviews, competitor analysis, and literature review, we identified key user problems and translated them into concrete feature ideas.

This helped us ensure that every design decision directly addressed real postpartum needs

[link:](#)



Based on insights from our interviews, competitive analysis, and literature review, we identified key features a postpartum fitness app should include to truly support new mothers.

Across all research, we saw that women value exercise after childbirth but face barriers such as lack of time, low energy, physical recovery challenges, and uncertainty about what is safe. Many said they would use an app if it felt helpful, realistic, and trustworthy.

To address this, the app should be easy to navigate, offer flexible home-based workouts with different intensity levels, and function smoothly without technical issues. Clear expert guidance is essential, especially around postpartum recovery topics like pelvic floor health and C-section healing, to help users feel safe.

Motivation also plays a big role. Features such as realistic goal-setting, progress tracking, and community support can help mothers stay engaged. Many participants highlighted the importance of feeling connected and supported during this life stage.

Personalized nutrition support was also highly valued, particularly when tailored to postpartum needs. Finally, pricing transparency is important: lower pricing encourages trial, while higher pricing must clearly communicate value.

Recommended Features:

1: Customized support for postpartum bodies

Feature: "Postpartum Profiling" - will help users to put in their specific needs, for example pelvic floor issues, C-section recovery or breastfeeding difficulties, and provide customized workout routines and exercises referred to their needs.

Feature: "Modified Exercises" - include videos and instructions for adapt exercises to address common physical limitations after childbirth, such as cesarean section scars or pelvic floor problems.

2 : Clear instructions

Feature: "Step-by-Step Videos" - include video demonstrations of each exercise, with clear explanations and slow-motion playback for easier learning.

Feature: "Voice Guidance" - provide voice guidance throughout workouts to help users stay on track and focused.

Feature: "Exercise Library" - create a comprehensive library of exercises with clear descriptions, photos, and videos for easy reference.

3 : Flexibility and adaptability

Feature: "Customizable Workouts" - allow users to create their own workout routines based on their fitness level, goals, and availability.

Feature: "Progress Tracking" - allow users to track their progress and adjust their workouts accordingly.

4 : Postpartum Guidelines

Feature: "Postpartum Safety Guidelines" - provide clear guidelines on when it's safe to start exercising after giving birth, based on medical research and expert advice.

Feature: "Pregnancy-Proof Exercises" - include exercises that are specifically designed to be gentle on the body during the postpartum period.

5 : Community support

Feature: "Social Sharing" - allow users to share their progress and connect

with other mothers who are going through similar experiences.

Feature: "Community Forums" - create online forums where users can ask questions, share tips, and get support from other mothers.

6: Realistic goals

Feature: "Realistic Goal-Setting" - provide realistic goals and milestones for postpartum exercise, acknowledging that it's a process that takes time.

Feature: "Celebrating Small Wins" - encourage users to celebrate small victories and progress along the way, rather than focusing solely on grand goals.

7 : Content variety

Feature: "Exercise Library" - create a comprehensive library of exercises with varying intensity levels, styles, and formats for example yoga, Pilates, strength training etc.

Feature: "New Content Added Regularly" - regularly update the app with new exercises, workouts, and content to keep users engaged and challenged.

Feature: "User-Generated Content" - allow users to submit their own exercises or workouts for inclusion in the app.

8 : Technical functions

Feature: "User-Friendly Interface" - design an intuitive and user-friendly interface that is easy to navigate, even for those who are new to exercise or technology.



Feature: "Tech Support" - offer dedicated technical support for users who encounter issues with the app.

Feature: "Regular Updates" - regularly update the app with bug fixes and improvements to ensure a smooth user experience.

9 : Free Trial period

Feature: "Free Trial Period" - offer a free trial period or demo version of the app to allow users to try before committing to a subscription.

10: Nutrition plans, Advice

Feature: "Nutrient tracker" - feature to track the intake of key nutrients (vitamins, minerals) so that users meet their nutritional needs.

Feature: "Recipes" - database of recipes tailored for postpartum recovery, focusing on nutrient-dense and easy-to-prepare meals.

Feature: "Tailored Meal Plans" - Personalized meal plans that align with the user's diet preferences and health goals.

Feature: "Meal reminder" - Notifications to users to stay on track with their meals, hydration in their nutrition plan

Feature: "Expert Tips and Advice" - Expert advice on nutrition from dietitians and nutritionists

Feature: "Input diet preference and health goals" - Expert advice on nutrition from dietitians and nutritionists

